



Color Theory

Understanding the Language of Color

Why do some colors feel exciting?

Why do others feel calm?

Why does a brand choose green over red?

What is Color Theory?

"Color is the first thing people notice about a design."

Color theory is a set of rules that helps artists and designers use color on purpose.

Instead of just picking colors you like, color theory gives you a system. It helps you choose colors that work together, send a message, and make people feel something.



Art

Painters have used color rules for centuries.



Design

Designers pick colors that match a brand's message.



Marketing

Brands use color to make you feel and buy.

The Color Wheel

Every color you will ever use starts here.

Primary Colors

These are the three starting colors. You cannot mix other colors to make them.



Red Yellow Blue

Secondary Colors

Mix two primary colors together and you get a secondary color.



Orange Green Purple

Tertiary Colors

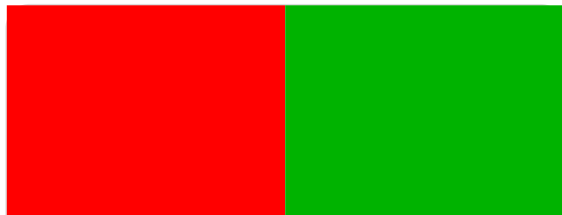
Mix a primary and a secondary color to get a tertiary color. There are six of them.



Red-Orange Yellow-Green Blue-Green

Complementary Colors

Complementary colors sit directly across from each other on the color wheel. Together they create strong contrast and make each other look brighter.



Red + Green

Used in: Stop signs & holiday decorations



Blue + Orange

Used in: Sports teams, bold posters



Purple + Yellow-Green

Used in: Grape packaging, energy drinks

Analogous Colors

What are they?

Analogous colors are colors that sit next to each other on the color wheel. They always look good together because they are related.

Think of a sunset. Orange, red, and yellow are all next to each other. That is why it looks so beautiful.

Use analogous colors when you want a design to feel calm, natural, and peaceful.

Sunset Palette



Ocean Palette

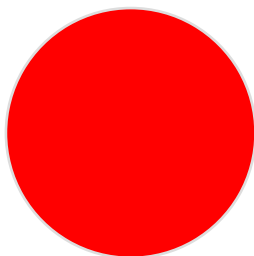


Forest Palette

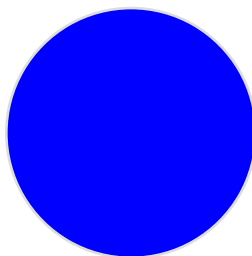


Triadic Colors

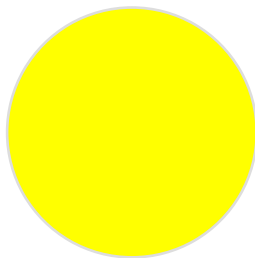
Three colors spaced equally around the color wheel. Bold, balanced, and energetic.



Red



Blue



Yellow

▲ *Primary Triad*

When to use triadic colors:

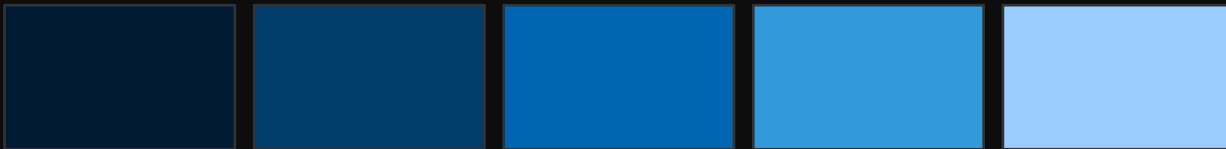
- When you want your design to feel exciting and bold
- For posters, logos, or social media graphics
- When you need all three colors to stand out equally
- Great for kids brands, sports, and games

Color Palettes

A color palette is a small set of colors a designer picks and uses everywhere in a project.

Monochromatic

One color in many shades. Very clean and professional.



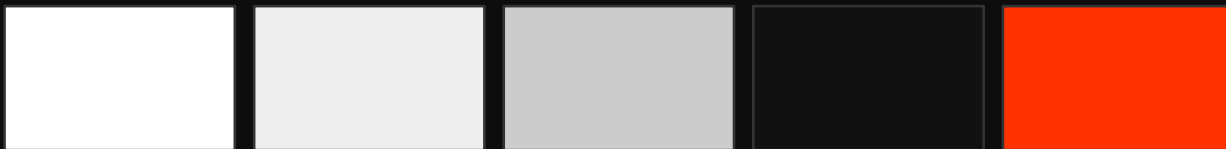
Complementary

Two opposite colors. High energy and contrast.



Neutral + Accent

Simple background colors with one bold pop of color.



Key Rule: Pick 3 to 5 colors and stick to them. Using too many colors makes a design look messy.

Color Psychology

Colors make you feel things. Smart designers use this on purpose.

RED

Energy | Urgency | Power

Brands: YouTube, Target, Coca-Cola

ORANGE

Fun | Warmth | Creativity

Brands: Amazon, Fanta, Nickelodeon

YELLOW

Happiness | Attention | Caution

Brands: McDonald's, IKEA, Snapchat

GREEN

Nature | Health | Growth

Brands: Starbucks, Whole Foods, John Deere

BLUE

Trust | Calm | Intelligence

Brands: Facebook, Samsung, Ford

PURPLE

Luxury | Mystery | Creativity

Brands: Cadbury, Hallmark, Twitch

How Brands Use Color



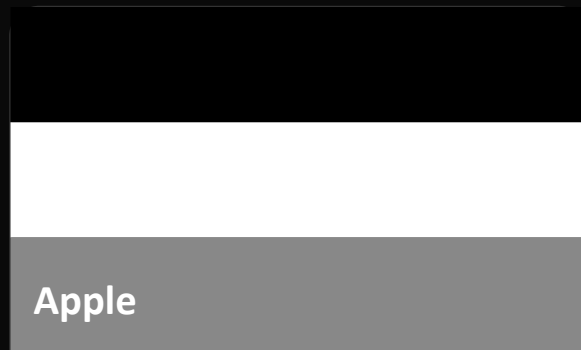
McDonald's

Red creates hunger and urgency. Yellow creates happiness and energy. Together they make you want to eat fast and feel good about it.



Coca-Cola

Red is bold, exciting, and energetic. White keeps it clean and classic. This combo has not changed in over 100 years.



Apple

Black, white, and silver say: simple, premium, and modern. No color = no distraction. The product speaks for itself.

Customer Touchpoints

Where does a customer actually see a brand's colors?

A touchpoint is any moment when a customer sees or interacts with a brand. Every single touchpoint uses the same colors. That is what makes a brand feel familiar.

Think About Starbucks:



The Cup

Green and white, every time, every location.



The App

Same green, same fonts, same icons as the store.



The Storefront

Green sign, warm wood tones inside.



The Napkins

Even the napkins match the brand.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT

Coming up next session, you will pick a real brand and analyze it.

Choose a brand you know. Here is what you will look for:

01

Name the colors

What 2 to 4 colors does this brand use most?

02

Identify the type

Are the colors complementary, analogous, or something else?

03

Analyze the psychology

What do those colors make people feel? Why do you think the brand chose them?

04

Spot the touchpoints

Where do you see the colors? App, building, packaging, website?

What You Learned Today



- Color theory gives designers a system for choosing colors on purpose.
- The color wheel shows primary, secondary, and tertiary colors.
- Complementary, analogous, and triadic colors are the main relationships.
- A color palette is a small set of colors used consistently across a design.
- Colors create feelings. Designers use this to influence how people react.
- Brands use color at every touch-point so customers always recognize them.